THE UGANDA SCHOOLS RUGBY ASSOCIATION

2026

COMPETITION MANUAL

Contents

Section 1 – Introduction

Section 2 – Team Information

Section 3 – Rules and Regulations

Section 4 – League Structure

Section 5 – Tournament Format

Section 6 – Penalties

Section 7 – Participation Fees

Section 8 – Disputes

Section 9 – Points system

Section 10 – Series Rankings

Section 11 – Match Duration and knock-out match resolution

Section 12 – Cancelled and abandoned matches

Section 13 – Declaration of squads

Section 14 – Substitution

Section 15 – Field of Play

Section 16 – Technical Zone

Section 17 – Awards

Section 18 – League Officials

Section 1 – Introduction

1.1 This manual is intended to set out the rules, regulations, and operational information in areas required by the Participating schools in planning, preparing for, and participating in, USRA Tournaments, 2026. This document also contains the Tournament Participation Agreement. This is a legal document that each Participating school MUST sign and return the signed copy to USRA Secretariat before the kickoff of the tournament. No school shall be allowed to participate before returning the signed copy of this manual.

Participating Schools are responsible for the actions of all persons under their control as defined in the manual and are accountable for the compliance of those persons with these Terms of Participation. Participating schools are subject to penalties for any breach of the specifications of these Terms of Participation.

1.2 ***Variations from the Specifications of these Terms of Participation***

USRA Technical Committee reserves the right, at any time (whether before or during the Tournament) to make or vary rules and give directions as to the conduct of the Tournament, or in respect of matters relating to the Tournament, including the contents of these Terms of Participation, in accordance with the Participation Agreement.

Section 2 – Team Information

2.1 Team Size

- **15's** - The official team squads must be limited to a maximum of 27, comprising 23 players and 4 team officials.
- **7's** – The official team squad must be limited to 17, comprising 13 players and 4 team officials.

Teams who intend to bring more than 4 management staff may officially notify the USRA technical committee to get a clearance.

2.2 Eligibility

- A player is eligible to participate in the USRA Tournament if they fulfill the following requirements.
- All players MUST be enrolled in the schools they are playing for and shall be required to present the following documents;

- **U15**

1. Birth certificate
2. School ID
3. Recommendation from his or her primary school

- **U17**

1. School ID
2. PLE Pass slip

- **U20**

1. School ID
2. PLE Pass slip

In the event that a PLE Pass Slip is lost, a police letter will be required and a recommendation from the primary school of the affected candidate / athlete with the PLE index number clearly captured in the recommendation. This will be subjected to a verification process at a fee.

2.3 Age Criteria

a) It is the responsibility of each Participating School to ensure its players comply to the age requirements as determined and communicated by USRA ExCom.
b) Written agreement from the under 17 players as acceptance of any associated risk with playing with players who may be stronger and more physically developed than him/her in the upper age category.

Section 3 - Rules and Regulations

1. All matches shall be played in accordance with the current WR Laws of the game
2. All school teams have to be accompanied by a school games teacher
3. Each school shall present a school album for screening
4. For 15s:
    - Players playing in the U20 category MUST be born between 1st January, 2006 and 31st December 2008 inclusive.
    - Players playing in the U17 category MUST be born between 1st January 2008 to 31st December 2010 inclusive.
    - Players playing in the U15 category must be born between 1st January 2010 and 31st December 2012 inclusive.

5. For 7s:
    - Players playing in the ***Main cup*** shall STRICTLY be between 17 and 20 years of age.
    - Players playing in the ***Shield competition*** shall STRICTLY be between 15 and 17 years of age.
6. NO team shall be allowed to fill-in more than two players who have ever featured in the Nile Premiere league at the same time.
7. NO player shall feature for two different school team (say U15 and U17) in the same season's competition except when moving up a category, however if that player moves shall not move back down.
8. Each school shall present a team players list before the start of the season.
9. School Teams are required to nominate a head coach, team manager and MEDICAL OFFICER, whose names shall reach USRA along with the list of registered players
10. All coaches must be qualified with at least a Level one coaching certificate.
11. All medical persons shall be registered members of the Uganda Rugby Medical Society and hosting school.
12. All matches shall be played as per the fixtures; any change of the fixtures shall be communicated to the chairman USRA no later than forty-eight hours (48) to the scheduled date.
13. Each host team shall provide qualified medical personnel and a fully kitted ambulance. If the host cannot provide the medical facilities, they should communicate to the chairman of the competition committee 48hrs before the match
14. Failure by any team to turn up on time a walkover shall be awarded after 25 minutes of the scheduled kick off time
15. A school that fails to honor two consecutive fixtures without official communications, shall automatically be relegated

Section 4 - League Structure

15s

1. There shall be 8 teams for boys in the Premiership and the rest play in the second division. Girls' teams will also play in their own league under USRA and supported by the RDO's and/or District Rugby coordinators.
2. Each premier team shall have three categories, U15, U17 and U20.
3. There shall be two groups of 4 teams with teams playing a round robin group stage. Top 2 teams per group to advance into a home and away knockout Semi Finals and Finals respectively.
4. At each host venue all categories shall play.

7s

1. For the 2026 season, there shall be four circuits.
2. The Final circuit shall double as the Kabaka Coronation Cup that will be hosted at a venue determined by USRA ExCom. To participate in this circuit, a school must have participated in at least two of the previous circuits

3. Each school shall present one or two teams.
4. There shall be a main cup for the main teams and a shield cup for the feeder sides.
5. At each host venue all teams shall play.

Section 5- Tournament Format

1. All the tournaments will follow the same format with a pool and a knock-out stage.

Section 6 – Penalties

1. A school that is not accompanied by a school teacher shall forfeit the match
2. A school that fields an over or under age player shall be docked four league points
3. A player found to play for two categories shall be disqualified from the competition
4. A school that fields a player in two categories shall lose the match by forfeit or given a financial penalty
5. Use of non-eligible, players (players not currently enrolled in such a school) shall lose the match by forfeit and be docked four (4) league points.
6. A team that repeatedly violates the terms stated in the competition and tournament manuals shall be disqualified from the league.
7. A player who accumulates three yellow cards in the school's league shall be suspended for one match
8. A player who receives a red card shall miss the next two games/matches,
9. Red cards may also be subject to sanctions under WR regulation 20 at the will of the competition committee.

Section 7 - Participation Fees

Each participating team will pay a participation fee as determined and communicated by USRA in the invitational letters.

Section 8 – Disputes

A panel will be established to which any school or player shall petition to at a non-refundable fee of one hundred thousand shillings only.
A team shall have a right to appeal to USRA ExCom at a non-refundable fee of Two Hundred Thousand Shillings Only. This shall be paid before the appeal is heard.
The final appellate body is Uganda Rugby Union appeals committee with a fee of UGX 250,000/

Section 9 - Points system

15's

- For a WIN, the winning team is awarded four (4) points;
- A bonus point is awarded for WINNING by three (3) tries or more
- For a DRAW, each team is awarded two (2) points;
- For a LOSS, the losing team is awarded zero (0) points and a bonus point for losing within 7pts
- If a team abandons a match or fails to show up the opposing team will get 4 points and (+20 points scored)

7's

- Teams will play each other in each Pool on a round robin basis. Match points will be awarded for each pool match on the following basis:

  Win = 3 Points
  Draw = 2 Points
  Loss = 1 Point
  No show=0
  Point
- No extra time shall be played during the pool phase
- At the conclusion of the Pool phase, the Teams in a pool are ranked based on their cumulative match points, and identified respectively as winner, runner up, third and fourth etc.
- If, at the completion of the Pool phase, two teams have played each other resulting in a draw OR more than two Teams are level on Match points, the following criteria will be used in the following order until one of the Teams can be determined as the higher ranked:

i. the Team which has the best difference between points scored for and points scored against in all its Pool Matches shall be the higher ranked;
ii. the Team which has the best difference between tries scored for and tries scored against in all its Pool Matches shall be the higher ranked;
iii. the Team which has scored most points in all its Pool Matches shall be the higher ranked;
iv. the Team which has scored most tries in all its Pool Matches shall be the higher ranked; and
v. if none of the above produce a result, then it will be resolved with a toss of a coin

Section 10 - Series Rankings

All teams participating in USRA 7s Tournaments will receive competition points according to their ranking at the end of each circuit. The overall winner of the League will be determined by the Team with the most points as set out in the League table below:

1. Series Point System

1st	22
2nd	19
3rd	17
4th	15
5th	13
6th	12
7th	10
8th	10
9th	8
10th	7
11th	5
12th	5

In the event of a Tournament being abandoned, there will be no League points allocated.

2. Criteria of resolution

i. In the event of two or more Teams being equal on points for any position on the League table, the Team which has the best difference between points scored for and points scored against in all the Series Matches shall be the higher ranked;

ii. In the event of (i) above not providing a decision, the Team which has the best difference between tries scored for and tries scored against in all its Series Matches shall be the higher ranked;

iii. In the event of (ii) above not providing a decision, the position on the Series table will be considered equal (i.e., a tie)

Section 11 - Match Duration and knock-out match resolution

15s.

- The duration of these matches shall be as follows
    a) U20 games shall be played for 80 minutes (40 minutes each half)
    b) U17 games shall be played for 60 minutes (30 minutes each half)
    c) U15 games shall be played for 50 minutes (25 minutes each half)
- No extra time shall be played.
- During knockouts, in an event that the game ends in a draw, both teams shall be required to present 3 kickers who will take part in a drop kick competition at different marks at the 22metre line as determined by the referee.
- In an event that no winner is determined after that; each team shall be required to present 2 extra players.
- In an event that no winner is determined after the 5 kickers, the following resolution criteria shall be followed.

(i) the Team that has received fewer red cards during the Match is declared the winner;

(ii) the Team that has received fewer yellow cards during the Match is declared winner;

(iii)If no winner is determined after that, there shall be a coin toss by both captains to determine the winner

7s

a) The duration of all matches will be seven minutes each half with a two-minute half time interval or as determined by the USRA Technical committee.
b) During the knock-out competitions, in the event of a match being drawn at the end of normal time, sudden death (next score wins) / extra time will be played until a winner is determined. A two (2) minute water break will be held at the end of normal time.
c) The extra time is played in periods of TWO (2) minutes. After each period the Teams will change ends without interval. In extra time the Team which scores first will immediately be declared the winner without further play.
d) A toss by the Team Managers/Captains and the Referee will be conducted to determine which team will kick off the commencement of the extra time and chose which end the team will kick off from

Section 12 - Cancelled and abandoned matches

Apart from the willful abandonment of a Match and subsequent expulsion in the event of a Match having to be stopped after its commencement under the provisions of the Laws of the Game, then subject to confirmation by the Disputes Committee, the following procedure shall apply.

(a) Where a Match has been abandoned either at half-time or at any time in the second half, the result and any points and tries scored by each Team in the Match shall stand.

(b) Where a pool Match has been abandoned during the first half the result shall be declared a draw. In this instance, each Team will be awarded two Match points and any points and tries scored will count towards the total points and tries scored by each Team in all their pool Matches

(c) If a match is abandoned or cancelled arising out of any issue such as loss of light, unplayable weather or conditions deemed unplayable by the Tournament Officials In the knock-out phase, if the Teams are drawn, the winner shall be determined in accordance with the following criteria in the following order:

(i) the Team which has scored most tries during the Match is declared the winner;

(ii) the Team that has scored most points during the Tournament is declared the winner;

(iii) the Team which has scored most tries during the Tournament is declared the winner;

(iv) the Team that has received fewer red cards during the Match is declared the winner;

(v) the Team that has received fewer yellow cards during the Match is declared winner;

(vi) the Team that has received fewer red cards during the Tournament is declared the winner;

(vii) the Team that has received fewer yellow cards during the Tournament is declared winner;

(viii) if none of the above produce a result, then the winner will be determined with a toss of a coin. As per the Laws of the Game (Variations Seven-a-side), a match cannot be played or continued to be played if one of the teams has less than 5 players available to play e.g., injury, illness or player sanctions. In this case, the Match Commissioner shall refer the matter to the designated Tournament Disputes Committee who will, make the decision on the result of the Match, taking into account the time in the Match when the number of available Players was reduced to fewer than 5, and the circumstances of the Match at the time.

Section 13 - Declaration of squads

a) Team managers will be required to send the names of the 23 players, 4 officials for XVs and 12 players, 4 officials for 7s, before the games begin
b) All players used for the game must be registered on the game sheet submitted before start of the game
c) Use of unregistered/ineligible players will lead to forfeiture of the match and will be referred for further handling by the tournament management committee. The result of the game will be 20-00 to the non-offending team
d) Should both teams use unregistered ineligible player(s), both teams will not score league points for that match.

Section 14 - Substitutions

Rolling substitution system will be used

Section 15 - Field of play

- Only Players, the referee, assistant referees, water carriers and medically trained persons, in order to tend to an injured Player may enter the playing area. During the half time interval coaches, water carriers and camera crews may enter the playing area but they must leave before resumption of play and must not do anything to delay the punctual resumption of play.

Section 16 - Technical Zone

a) Each Team is allowed to have the following 4 personnel in the technical zone during their Matches: Coach, Team Manager, Medic/Physiotherapist. 8 reserve Players and 5 reserve players for 15s and 7s respectively
b) Team medic(s), as described in (a) above, are permitted to follow play along the touchlines, on the technical zone side of the field of play, and on the far side depending on the number of medics assigned to the team. These are classified as roaming medics. Schools are responsible for their athletes' injuries.
c) Only qualified coaches (Level 1 minimum) will be allowed in the technical zone. Non-qualified coaches shall not be allowed in the technical zone.

Section 17 – Awards

Trophies and medals shall be awarded to the winners according to their ranking at the end of the season. (TBC).

Section 18 - League officials

1. Tournament Director: Mr. Okello Dickson
2. Tournament Manager: Baguma Victor
3. Manager, Technical Affairs: Matsiko Vian
4. Manager, Referees: Saudah Adiru
5. Coordinator, Medical: (URMS)
6. Communication and Marketing: Ms. Cynthia Roy Nabukeera

PARTICIPATION AGREEMENT

Formal Acceptance by ……. (School)

EACH TEAM MEMBER representing the Participating School whose name is to be supplied by the Participating School and who is also to enter into this Agreement by executing a formal acceptance in the terms set out in the Competition manual.

By signing, the school management and its players recognize all the terms of the tournament manual including the regulations.

BETWEEN UGANDA SCHOOLS RUGBY ASSOCIATION (USRA)

And

(SCHOOL)……

NAME OF OFFICIAL ……

SIGNATURE /DATE ……

Designation…….

EXECUTED AS DEED.

NB. Email the signed copy of this document to usrasecretariat@gmail.com before the start of each tournament.